



Rise. Register. Grow.

In business, leaders often talk about a "VUCA" world — one defined by Volatility, Uncertainty, Complexity, and Ambiguity (Bennett & Lemoine, 2014). Prices shift overnight, regulations change, and the road to formalising a small food business can feel impossible to predict. That is exactly the world our traders are operating in. So in this VUCA world, we are here to help you VUKA ;-)

The Complete Journeys: 1–10

This is the unified VUKA curriculum: every journey a food trader needs, from checking whether you're ready to grow, right through to scaling into a bigger business, in one consistent, scenario-driven format.

Each lesson takes 3–7 minutes: a real scenario, a quick explanation, one practical tip, a quick challenge, and a badge.

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Journey 1: Is Your Business Ready to Grow?

"You're thinking about a second stall, more stock, or your first helper. But how do you actually know if you're ready, or just hopeful?"

Growing too soon, before your foundation is strong, can put a trader into debt or under strain. This journey helps you check your own signs before you spend a single extra rand.



The Five Signs You're Actually Ready

"Every trader dreams of expanding. But how many actually check if the timing is right first?"

Business advisors point to a consistent set of signs that show a business has a strong enough base to grow safely. Your income is steady or growing over several months, not just on the odd good week. A high number of your customers come back again and again, which shows real trust. You regularly sell out or have to turn customers away, meaning there's more demand than you can currently meet. Your notebook records are in order, so you can actually see your profit trend over time. And you have some savings or a buffer, so you're not relying on every rand of today's profit to restock tomorrow (Startup Mag, 2025; Lula, 2025).



QUICK TIP Don't wait until all five signs are perfect. Even having three or four in place is often enough to take one small, careful step.



QUICK CHALLENGE Go through the five signs above as a checklist against your own notebook records, and note which ones you already have.

Complete this and earn:  "Growth Signal" badge



What "Growing" Actually Looks Like

"Growing doesn't always mean a whole new shop. What's the smallest next step that would actually take you further?"

Growth doesn't have to mean a second stall straight away. For a food trader, it can look like adding a new product line, extending your trading hours for flexibility, taking on a helper, or, eventually, opening a second spot. The smaller the step, the smaller the risk if it doesn't work out exactly as planned.



QUICK TIP Match your growth step to your strongest sign. If you keep selling out, extending your hours or adding stock is a safer first move than renting a second stall.



QUICK CHALLENGE Pick one growth option from this lesson, and write down what would need to be true first before you commit to it.

Complete this and earn:  "Ready to Rise" badge



Journey 2: Keep More of What You Earn

"You worked hard for every rand today. So where did half of it go by the time you got home?"

This journey is about understanding your numbers, cutting the costs you don't need, keeping proof of what you earn, and getting that money somewhere safer than your pocket.



Know Your Three Numbers

"If someone asked what your business actually made last month, could you answer with a number, or just a guess?"



Every trader needs to know three numbers. Turnover is all the money that comes in from sales, before any costs are taken out. Expenses are everything you spend: stock, transport, packaging, permit fees, data and airtime. Profit is turnover minus expenses, and it's the only number that tells you what you actually made.

 **QUICK TIP** At the end of each week, add up all your "Money In" and "Money Out," then subtract. That's your weekly profit, in under five minutes.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** This week, add up your Money In and Money Out, and work out your actual profit.

Complete this and earn:  **"Numbers Know-How" badge**

Don't Mix Business and Personal Money

"If your business money and your taxi fare money live in the same pocket, how would you ever know which one you're spending?"

Many traders lose track of profit because business and personal cash get mixed together in one pocket or purse. Keep two or three separate containers or accounts: one for the business, one for personal or household spending, and ideally one for emergencies. Try paying yourself a fixed amount, like an employee's wage, instead of just taking money out whenever you need it. Set aside 10% to 20% of your weekly profit into a savings container, stokvel, or account too, so you've got a buffer for slower weeks.

 **QUICK TIP** Treat your own "salary" as a fixed weekly expense, just like stock or rent. It protects your profit from disappearing invisibly.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Set up, or find, three separate places for your money this week: business, personal, and emergency.

Complete this and earn:  **"Separate & Secure" badge**

Stop the Leaks

"You didn't have a bad sales week. So why did you end up with less profit than last month?"

Many small businesses lose money not because they don't sell enough, but because their costs are too high or badly managed. Compare prices between at least two suppliers before committing to one regularly. Reduce waste, especially with fresh food, by only buying what you can realistically sell before it spoils. Avoid mashonisas and unregistered lenders altogether: their interest rates can turn a R1,000 loan into R2,000 or more owed (National Debt Advisors, 2021). Every month, look back through your notebook and ask whether there's a cheaper, equally good option for your biggest cost items.

 **QUICK TIP** Loyalty to one supplier is good, but not if it's quietly costing you money every single week. It's worth the awkward conversation to ask around.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Identify your single biggest weekly expense, other than stock, and brainstorm one way to reduce it.

Complete this and earn:  **"Cost Cutter" badge**

Keep Proof of Every Rand

"A funder asks to see your trading history. What would you actually show them right now?"

Nationally, most unregistered South African businesses keep no financial records at all. Without records, you can't prove your income to a bank, can't apply for funding, and can't really tell if your business is making money. The fix is simple: one notebook, divided into "Money In" and "Money Out." Write every transaction down on the day it happens, even small ones. Keep every receipt from suppliers or the municipality in one plastic sleeve or file, sorted by month. Total everything up weekly and monthly, this becomes your simple financial record and your proof of income when you're ready to apply for support.



 **QUICK TIP** If you have a smartphone, a free app like Yoco or a simple notes app can back up these records digitally too, on top of your notebook.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Start today's page. Write down your first two transactions of the day, right now.

Complete this and earn:  **"Proof Keeper" badge**



Bank It, Even Without CIPC

"All your profit is sitting in a plastic bag under your bed. What happens if it goes missing tomorrow?"

You do not need to register with CIPC to open a business bank account as a sole proprietor. Several South African banks offer accounts built specifically for informal, unregistered traders. The Capitec Entrepreneur Account works off an existing Capitec GlobalOne personal account and your South African ID, with no minimum deposit to open. The TymeBank Everyday Business Account works from an existing TymeBank "Good Friends" personal account, is free to open, and is set up in the app under My Profile > My Details > Business Benefits. Depositing your cash regularly, even weekly, builds a transaction history, which is exactly what you'll need later for funding or a card machine.

 **QUICK TIP** Keeping cash on your person or at home is one of the biggest theft risks a trader faces. Even a small regular deposit reduces that risk.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Choose Capitec or TymeBank, and find out exactly what you need to open an account this week.

Complete this and earn:  **"Banked & Building" badge**



Journey 3: Make Your Business Official

"Imagine Pick n Pay wants to buy your amagwinya tomorrow. Are you ready?"

Most big buyers, funders, and banks won't work with you until your business is official. This journey walks you through exactly what "official" means, one small step at a time. No lectures, just what to do next.



Why Bother Registering?

"You're already selling 100 plates a week from your yard. Why would you need any paperwork at all?"

Right now, you and your business are the same thing in the eyes of the law. If something goes wrong, it's your personal problem, not just "the business's" problem. Once you register, your business becomes its own thing, separate from you (Companies Act 71 of 2008). That's what opens the door to bank accounts, big contracts, and funding.

 **QUICK TIP** You don't have to register everything at once. Start with the one piece of paper that unlocks the most doors: your CIPC registration (next lesson).

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Write down one thing you'd do differently if a big retailer called you tomorrow.

Complete this and earn:  **"Getting Serious" badge**



Let's Make It Official

"Someone asks: 'Is your business registered?' What do you actually say?"

CIPC (the Companies and Intellectual Property Commission) is where every South African business gets its legal ID (Companies Act 71 of 2008). You register online at cipc.co.za. Once you're registered, your business has its own name and its own legal identity, separate from you personally.



 **QUICK TIP** Keep your CIPC certificate saved as a photo on your phone. You'll need to show it again and again, for permits, for the bank, and for funders.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Go to cipc.co.za and check what documents you'll need before you start.

Complete this and earn:  **"Officially Official" badge**



Get Your Food Permit Sorted

"Could a health inspector actually shut you down tomorrow?"

Yes, if you don't have a Certificate of Acceptability (called a CoA), you are trading illegally, even if your food is amazing. This is a permit from your local municipality that proves your kitchen is safe. It's a legal requirement under Regulation R638 (R638 of 2018).

 **QUICK TIP** Your CoA is tied to YOU and YOUR exact spot. If you move stalls or change hands, you need a brand new one. It doesn't transfer.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Find your nearest municipal Environmental Health office and save the number in your phone.

Complete this and earn:  **"Food Safe" badge**



The Other Permits People Forget

"You've got your CoA. Are you actually fully legal now?"

Not quite. Most food businesses also need a separate Business Licence from the municipality, under the Businesses Act (Businesses Act 71 of 1991). If you cook from home, you may also need permission for your property to be used for business (called zoning). Using gas, or planning to sell alcohol? Add a Gas Certificate and a Liquor Licence to your list too.

 **QUICK TIP** Ask your municipality for a full permit checklist on your first visit. Most people find out about a missing permit one at a time, the hard way.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** List every permit you currently have, then circle the ones you're missing.

Complete this and earn:  **"Paper Trail Pro" badge**



Sorting Out Your Tax

"If your business made R50,000 last month, do you owe SARS anything?"

It depends on how much your business earns in a year. As of April 2026, you only have to register for VAT once you earn more than R2.3 million a year (SARS, Budget 2026 FAQs). If you earn less, a simpler system called Turnover Tax might work better for you, since it replaces several taxes with one easy calculation.

 **QUICK TIP** Don't guess your number. Check sars.gov.za or visit a SARS branch to see exactly where your business sits, since these thresholds get updated over time.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Add up roughly what your business made in the last 12 months, and compare it to R2.3 million.

Complete this and earn:  **"Tax Smart" badge**



From Side Hustle to Official Business

"You sell from a stall, a yard, or your kitchen table right now. How do you actually get to be fully legal?"

You don't have to do it all in one week. Most people go in this order: check your spot is zoned correctly, then register with CIPC, then apply for your Business Licence and Food Permit together (inspectors often check



both at once), then sort out tax once you're properly trading. Since 2024, even spaza shops have had to register, so the government is watching this space more closely than before.

 **QUICK TIP** Pick ONE step to finish this week. Don't try to do everything at once.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Choose your next step, and put a date on it.

Complete this and earn:  "Levelling Up" badge



Journey 4: Customers Should Trust Your Food

"Would you eat in your own kitchen right now?"

Trust is the real product you're selling. The food is just how customers experience it. This journey shows you how to earn that trust, and prove it when someone asks.

Would You Eat In Your Own Kitchen?

"Be honest. Would you eat in your own kitchen right now?"

A health inspector checks a few basic things: is your prep area clean and easy to wipe down? Are your fridges cold enough? Do you keep raw meat away from cooked food? Is there somewhere for staff to wash their hands? These are the exact things Regulation R638 (R638 of 2018) checks before giving you a Food Permit.

 **QUICK TIP** Do your own mini-inspection once a week using this same list, before an inspector ever does it for you.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Walk through your kitchen right now and check these four things.

Complete this and earn:  "Kitchen Ready" badge

Five Things Customers Notice First

"Would a stranger trust your food from how it's packaged, before they even taste it?"

Customers judge food safety before they even eat, from your packaging, your labels, and how you handle food in front of them. If you sell pre-packaged food (not made-to-order), the law (R146) says your label needs a few key things: what the product is, the ingredients, how much is in the pack, and who made it. If it contains a common allergen, that has to be clearly stated too.

 **QUICK TIP** If you ever write something like "low sugar" or "high protein" on a label, the law (R146) requires a full nutrition table too, so only make that claim if you're ready to back it up.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Look at your current packaging. Does it have all five things a customer needs to see?

Complete this and earn:  "Trust Builder" badge



Keep Food Fresh For Longer

"How long can that chicken really sit out before it's a problem?"

Temperature is the single biggest food safety risk. Cold food needs to stay cold, hot food needs to stay hot, and the zone in between is where bacteria grows fastest. This is one of the main things inspectors check under R638 (R638 of 2018).

 **QUICK TIP** Get a cheap fridge thermometer. Guessing the temperature is how most food businesses fail an inspection.



✅ **QUICK CHALLENGE** Check your fridge temperature right now, and write it down.
Complete this and earn: ❄️ "Cold Chain Champion" badge

🧼 Simple Cleaning Habits That Keep You Legal

"If an inspector walked in right now, could your staff explain how they were trained?"

The law (R638 of 2018) says the person in charge of your kitchen must have proper food safety training, and so must anyone helping you handle food. You also need to keep some proof of this, even just a simple written record of who was trained and when.

💡 **QUICK TIP** Keep training proof as photos or notes on your phone. A simple record beats no record, every time.

✅ **QUICK CHALLENGE** Ask each person working with you: "When did you last get food safety training?"

Complete this and earn: 🧼 "Clean Team" badge

📦 Growing? New Rules Might Kick In

"What happens the moment you start canning your famous chilli sauce to sell in stores?"

Some products carry extra risk once you scale. Canned, smoked, or vacuum-packed foods are checked by a separate regulator (the NRCS), not just your municipality. If you want to supply a retailer like Pick n Pay or Checkers, they'll often ask for their own proof of food safety, on top of your permit.

💡 **QUICK TIP** Before you invest in new equipment for a new product type, check whether it changes your legal category. It can save you from an expensive mistake.

✅ **QUICK CHALLENGE** List any new products you're planning, and circle any that are canned, smoked, or vacuum-packed.

Complete this and earn: 📦 "Ready to Scale" badge

📦 Journey 5: "Never Run Out of Stock Again"

"Running out of a popular item halfway through the day sends that customer straight to a competitor. Ordering too much carries the same risk in reverse."

Most small South African food businesses still order stock based on guesswork. Below is a simple system that needs no software or technical expertise, just a bit of daily discipline.

📦 First In, First Out

"Yesterday's chicken is still in the back of the fridge. Which batch are you actually cooking with today?"

Know your "first in, first out" rule (FIFO). Always use or sell your oldest stock first, and put new deliveries behind existing stock, not in front of it. This is especially important for perishable food like meat, dairy, and vegetables (Xtraspace, 2024).

💡 **QUICK TIP** Make FIFO physical: literally move new stock to the back of the shelf or fridge every time a delivery arrives.

✅ **QUICK CHALLENGE** Check your fridge or storage now, is your oldest stock at the front, ready to be used first?

Complete this and earn: 📦 "FIFO Focused" badge





Set Your Par Levels

"How many kilograms of mealie meal do you need left before you start to worry?"

Set a simple "par level" for your top and best-selling items. Decide, from experience, on the minimum amount of each item you should have before you need to reorder, for example: "if I have less than 5kg of mealie meal left, I need to restock before my next trading day."



QUICK TIP Your par level doesn't need to be scientific. Your own experience of what "running low" feels like is a perfectly good starting point.



QUICK CHALLENGE Name any of your top 3 best-selling items and set a simple par level ("I reorder when I have less than ____") for each.

Complete this and earn:  **"Par Level Pro" badge**



Track What Runs Out

"You sold out of vetkoek by 11am again. Is that a coincidence, or a pattern?"

Check stock at the same time every day, ideally at the end of your trading, so it pairs naturally with your daily notebook routine. Write down what you sold out of, and when. If you notice you're consistently selling out of an item by midday, that's your sign to increase your order for that item.



QUICK TIP A pattern only becomes visible once it's written down. Two or three sellouts noted in the same notebook page tell you far more than memory alone.



QUICK CHALLENGE Tonight, write down what you sold out of, and roughly when it happened.

Complete this and earn:  **"Pattern Spotter" badge**



Order Smart, Not by Guesswork

"Your veggies spoil before you sell them, but you never run out of packaging. What does that tell you about how you're ordering?"

Match your ordering to your trading pattern. If certain items frequently get spoiled, order in smaller amounts more frequently for those (fresh vegetables, meat), while ordering slightly larger amounts less often for things that last longer (dry goods, packaging, disposables). Build reliable supplier relationships too, a supplier who knows you will often prioritise you when stock is tight, or give you advance warning of price changes (Ready Accounting, 2026).



QUICK TIP A five-minute conversation with your supplier about your usual order can save you an unplanned trip, or an unplanned shortage.



QUICK CHALLENGE Pick one perishable item and one dry good, and write a smarter ordering plan for each.

Complete this and earn:  **"Smart Stocker" badge**



Journey 6: Let Your Phone Bring You Customers

"Your food sells itself once people taste it. But how do they find you before that?"

Almost everyone in South Africa already uses WhatsApp, and it's free to use for business, only data is needed, which is cheaper than airtime. Very few food sellers set it up the right way. Done properly, it makes your business look professional and lets regular customers order ahead or check what's on the menu today.



Set Up WhatsApp Business

"Someone wants to order 10 plates for a stokvel meeting. Can they message you, or do they have to physically find your stall first?"

Download "WhatsApp Business" (not regular WhatsApp) from the Play Store or App Store, it's free. Register with a phone number, either a second SIM if you want to keep business and personal chats separate, or your existing number if it isn't already linked to regular WhatsApp. Verify the number by SMS code, then set up your Business Profile: business name, category ("Food & Beverage"), a short description of what you sell, your trading location and hours, and a clear profile photo of your food, stall, or logo.

 **QUICK TIP** Set a greeting message (e.g. "Thanks for messaging Thandi's Kota Corner! We're open Mon–Fri, 6am–17:30 at the taxi rank.") so customers get an instant response, even while you're busy serving.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Download the app and complete your profile: name, category, description, hours, and photo.

Complete this and earn:  **"Business Ready" badge**

Build a Catalogue Customers Can Browse

"A regular customer wants to know what's on the menu today, without calling you. What do they actually see?"

Under the Tools/Business Tools menu, select "Catalogue" and add your items, a photo, name, and price for each. Share your WhatsApp number or link with customers by writing it on a small sign or your menu board at your stall, so people can save it.

 **QUICK TIP** Keep your catalogue updated when items sell out or prices change. An outdated catalogue creates awkward conversations, not sales.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Add your 3 best-selling items to your catalogue with a photo, name, and price.

Complete this and earn:  **"Catalogue Built" badge**

Connect Facebook and Instagram

"Someone finds your food on Instagram. Can they message you straight from there, or do they have to go searching for your number separately?"

Facebook and Instagram can find your next customer, and you can connect them from the WhatsApp Business app itself. Open the app and go to Tools, tap Facebook & Instagram, then tap through to connect whichever platform you use. Log in to your Facebook or Instagram account, select the Page you want to link, and tap Connect WhatsApp.

 **QUICK TIP** You don't need both platforms at once. Start with whichever one your customers already use most.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Link one social media account to your WhatsApp Business this week.

Complete this and earn:  **"Connected" badge**

Take Photos People Want to Eat

"Would a photo of your food make a stranger hungry, or would they scroll straight past it?"

A photo of your food often decides whether a customer wants to try your dish or not. The picture sets the mood and makes people feel hungry before they've even tasted anything. That's why it matters for customers to see pictures of your food, whether on your menu or your WhatsApp catalogue. Good food photos also get people talking, sharing, commenting, and tagging friends. Posts with images get far more views than posts



with text alone (candyfoxstudio.com), so an appetising photo can create more interest than any description ever could.

 **QUICK TIP** Natural light does more for a food photo than any filter. Shoot near a window or outside, not under a dim stall light.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Take one appetising photo of your best-selling dish today, and save or post it.

Complete this and earn:  **"Camera Ready" badge**

Never Run Out of Things to Post

"It's been two weeks since your last post. What's actually stopping you?"

To keep your social media active without running out of ideas, share everyday moments from your business: preparing food, answering common customer questions, showing off your most popular menu items, or celebrating milestones. Keep an "idea bank" on your phone, a running list of trends, funny videos, and memorable pictures, so you always have content ready to post (Mercer, 2026).

 **QUICK TIP** You don't need a big production. A quick, honest photo of your actual stall usually beats a polished but generic one.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Start an "idea bank" note on your phone with three post ideas you could use this month.

Complete this and earn:  **"Idea Bank" badge**

Journey 7: Make People Remember You

"Two stalls sell the same kota, at the same price, in the same street. Why does one have a queue, and the other doesn't?"

Branding is how people see and remember your food business. It's built through every item of food you sell, and every interaction you have with customers, every single day.

What Branding Actually Means (And Why Bother)

"Let me go buy amagwinya from that lady" or "let me go buy amagwinya from [your business name]": which one turns a one-time buyer into a regular?"

More than 80% of people say trust is a leading reason why they buy, which is why branding matters no matter how big or small your food business is (Cloudfusion, 2025). Good branding helps people remember you, and people don't forget a business with the same colours and packaging every time (Dandu, 2015). It also builds trust: when customers see the same neat packaging and name every time, they feel emotionally safe buying from you, and with so many other people selling food, being memorable is what makes people choose you over someone else. Branding matters for your team too. It makes employees feel proud to be part of something real and growing, not just doing a small job (Cloudfusion, 2025).

 **QUICK TIP** Branding isn't a logo you design once and forget. It's the sum of every small, repeated detail a customer experiences.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Write down what you want a customer to say about your business to a friend, in their own words.

Complete this and earn:  **"Brand Aware" badge**

Know Who You're Really Talking To



"If your branding tried to please absolutely everyone, would anyone actually remember it?"

Start by understanding who your audience is: the specific group of people your food business serves, and the problem you're solving for them. Your branding should connect with their habits, likes, dislikes, and daily life. From there, build a brand strategy, a plan for your long-term goals and how your business will meet them. Two of its core elements are brand purpose (why does your business exist, and what value does it add to your audience's life? This becomes your mission statement) and brand vision (where do you see your business in the future? This shapes your long-term goals) (Yolisa Motha, 2021).

 **QUICK TIP** *If you're not sure who your audience is, look at who's already buying from you regularly, and build outward from there.*

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Answer in one sentence each: why does your business exist (purpose), and where do you see it in three years (vision)?

Complete this and earn:  **"Strategy Starter" badge**

Give Your Brand a Voice and a Vibe

"If your business could talk, would it crack a joke, or keep things strictly formal?"

Your brand also needs a personality, to make it more human and relatable. Think about how you want customers to see you: personable or corporate, exciting or calm, modern or rooted in tradition, playful or serious, accessible or premium. From that personality comes your brand voice, how your brand speaks and its tone, as if it were a real person talking to a customer. Finally, your brand tagline is a short, memorable line that sums all of this up in one breath (Yolisa Motha, 2021).

 **QUICK TIP** *Say your tagline out loud to a friend or family member. If they can repeat it back a minute later, it's working.*

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Write a one-line tagline for your business.

Complete this and earn:  **"Found My Voice" badge**

Build a Look People Recognise

"Could a customer spot your packaging in a crowd of ten other food stalls, from across the taxi rank?"

Beyond strategy, you need a brand identity, the visual elements that make up your brand. Your logo is the face of your business, the symbol people recognise before they even read your name; a good logo is simple, memorable, and affordable (some of the world's biggest logos cost only a few hundred rand to design). Even shapes carry meaning: round shapes feel warm and inviting, squares and rectangles feel strong and reliable, vertical lines feel bold, horizontal lines feel calm. Your colour palette matters too, since colours trigger feelings: red creates an urge to eat, green suggests fresh and healthy ingredients. Start with one to three main colours, then build outward. Keep your typography, the fonts you use, consistent everywhere your business name appears, from your menu to your social media (Yolisa Motha, 2021).

 **QUICK TIP** *Consistency beats perfection. The same colours and fonts used everywhere, even if simple, are more powerful than an elaborate design used inconsistently.*

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Pick your main one or two brand colours, and check they appear on your packaging, sign, and social media.

Complete this and earn:  **"Look Locked In" badge**

Journey 8: Work Smarter



"You're already working hard. But is your day actually working for you, or are you just reacting to whatever happens next?"

This journey pulls together the everyday habits, communication, time, teamwork, professionalism, your network, and how you get paid, that separate a business that runs smoothly from one that just runs.

Talk to Customers and Suppliers the Right Way

"A customer says yesterday's food was cold. Do you jump in to explain, or do you actually let them finish first?"

How well you communicate is directly linked to how well your business performs. Good communication builds trust, and trust is what brings a customer back. Greet every customer, a simple "Sawubona," "Dumela," or "Good morning" before talking about price or product sets a respectful tone. Listen before you speak: if a customer complains, let them finish before you respond, this is called active listening, and it's one of the most important skills a small business owner can have. Be clear about price and product every time, don't wait for a customer to ask twice. And keep the same polite, clear approach with suppliers: always confirm what you're ordering, how much it is, and when you'll pay or collect.

 **QUICK TIP** Practise the hard conversations before they happen. Run through a customer complaint or a late-delivery call with a family member so it feels familiar at the moment.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** At your next customer complaint, practise listening fully before you respond.

Complete this and earn:  **"Clear Communicator" badge**

Structure Your Day So It Doesn't Run You

"Where did your morning actually go? Could you account for every hour of it?"

It isn't a lack of product knowledge that holds most South African traders back, it's time management. On average, small business owners lose close to 96 minutes a day to disorganised or wasted time. A simple daily structure helps: before you leave home, prepare stock, count change, and check your equipment. Arrive early enough to set up before the busiest hour. During trading hours, focus only on selling and serving, don't do admin in the middle of a rush. Use quiet periods to restock, clean, or update your notebook. At the end of the day, count cash, write down what you sold and spent, and plan tomorrow's stock.

 **QUICK TIP** Set a phone alarm for "restock time" and "packing up time," so the day doesn't quietly run away from you.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Write out your ideal daily structure using the five stages above.

Complete this and earn:  **"Time Tamer" badge**

Build a Team, Even a Small One

"If you got sick tomorrow, would the person helping you know exactly what to do?"

Even a one- or two-person stall benefits from clear roles. Owners with reliable help, even informal help from family, can spend more time on things that actually grow the business, like sourcing better stock or scouting new selling spots. If you work with even one other person, agree out loud, don't just assume, on who cooks, who serves, and who handles the money. Have one clear "money person" at any given time, to avoid confusion and mistrust. Say thank you and acknowledge good work, it costs nothing and keeps helpers motivated. If you ever expand beyond one or two helpers, agree on simple, fair rules in advance: start and stop times, how pay or profit is split, and what happens if someone doesn't show up.

 **QUICK TIP** A written agreement doesn't need to be formal. A few lines in your notebook is enough to prevent most disputes before they start.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Write down, even in a few lines, who's responsible for what if you work with anyone else.



Complete this and earn: 🏆 "Team Builder" badge

Act Like the Pro You Already Are

"Would a municipal official, a supplier, and a first-time customer all take your business seriously today?"

Around 70% of small businesses in South Africa fail within their first year, often due to a lack of consistency and professional practice, not bad products. Professionalism is what makes people take you seriously even without a fancy shop. Sell from the same spot, at the same times, as much as possible, customers return to what they can rely on. Keep your hands, containers, and stall clean, which is also a legal hygiene requirement. Keep your pricing fair and consistent from customer to customer. If something goes wrong, apologise and offer a fair solution calmly, rather than arguing in public. And keep your word: if you tell a supplier or customer a time, price, or quantity, honour it. Reliability is your reputation.

💡 **QUICK TIP** Pick the one professionalism habit from this lesson that you're weakest on, and focus on just that one this week.

✅ **QUICK CHALLENGE** Pick one professionalism habit from this lesson to start today.

Complete this and earn: 🎩 "Pro Mode" badge

Build a Network That Backs You Up

"Who would warn you if an inspector was heading your way this afternoon?"

Traders with wider networks, other traders, suppliers, community contacts, get better access to information, funding, and support during hard times than those working in isolation. This is especially true at taxi ranks, where many vendors trade side by side. Get to know the traders around you: they're not only competitors, they can share supplier contacts, warn you about inspections, watch your stall, or refer overflow customers your way. Join or form a trader group, many taxi ranks and townships already have informal associations; your municipality's Economic Development office can usually tell you if one exists nearby. Keep supplier contacts saved on your phone with notes on pricing and reliability, and attend free local events run by SEDA or your municipality when you can. WhatsApp groups are a free, low-effort way to stay connected with everyone at once.

💡 **QUICK TIP** Your network is also your early-warning system. A quick WhatsApp message from a neighbouring trader can save you a fine, or a wasted trip.

✅ **QUICK CHALLENGE** Name three people, a trader, a supplier, and a community contact, you could call this week with a business question.

Complete this and earn:  "Well Connected" badge

Accept Card Payments with Yoco

"A customer wants to tap their card, but you only take cash. Do they buy anyway, or walk to the next stall?"

Nearly 6 million small South African businesses still only accept cash, but many customers now carry less of it, worried about theft. Accepting both cash and card gives you the best of both worlds, and you do not need to be CIPC-registered to sign up with Yoco. Go to yoco.com or download the Yoco app, select "Get Started," and choose Sole Proprietor. Enter your personal details and verify your identity with a photo of your South African ID. Add your trading address (your home address is fine if you trade from there) and a South African bank account in your own name. Choose your card machine, an entry-level Yoco Go costs roughly R800 upfront with a small daily fee only on days you use it, and no monthly fee. Once it arrives, it's already linked to your profile.

💡 **QUICK TIP** Card payments land in your account the next business day, not instantly, so plan your cash flow around that if you need cash on hand to buy stock.



✅ **QUICK CHALLENGE** Go to yoco.com or download the app and check exactly what you'd need to sign up.

Complete this and earn: 🇿🇦 "Tap to Trade" badge

Journey 9: Ready for Funding?

"You assumed you couldn't apply for funding because you're not registered with CIPC. Is that actually true?"

Many informal traders assume funding isn't for them. In reality, several South African funders specifically support informal and unregistered micro-enterprises, including street traders and vendors (RegInsights, 2024).

Funding That Doesn't Need CIPC

"You assumed you couldn't apply for funding because you're not registered. Is that actually true?"

The NYDA Grant Programme, run by the National Youth Development Agency, specifically supports businesses operating informally or formally, including street traders and vendors, as long as the business has a profit motive and is commercially capable of success. It's available to youth business owners aged 18 to 35, and you can apply through any NYDA branch, online, or by calling 0800 58 58 58 (Graduates24, n.d.). The SEDFA Township and Rural Entrepreneurship Programme, formed from the merger of SEFA, SEDA, and the CBDA, specifically targets township and rural businesses and supports formalising informal ones (Okhantu, 2025). Stokvels and savings groups aren't a "formal" funder, but they're a trusted, community-based way for many South African traders to access lump sums for stock or equipment without high interest.

💡 **QUICK TIP** Funders that support informal traders often get fewer applications than you'd expect. Not being registered yet shouldn't stop you from asking.

✅ **QUICK CHALLENGE** Look up whether NYDA or SEDFA has a branch or contact point near you.

Complete this and earn: 🇿🇦 "Funding Aware" badge

Get Funding-Ready Before You Need It

"A funding opportunity opens tomorrow with a two-week deadline. Could you apply in time?"

Start preparing now, before you actually apply. You'll typically need your ID, proof of your trading history (this is exactly why your notebook and bank account matter, they're the proof you can show a funder), a simple description of what the funding will be used for ("a second refrigerator to reduce spoilage," or "a bulk stock discount for the festive season"), and, if it's a loan rather than a grant, a basic idea of how you'll repay it.

💡 **QUICK TIP** Prepare your documents in one folder, physical or on your phone, before you need them, not while a deadline is ticking.

✅ **QUICK CHALLENGE** Write a few sentences on what you'd use funding for and how it would grow your income, the start of a simple funding pitch.

Complete this and earn: 📋 "Pitch Ready" badge

Journey 10: What's Your Next Move?



"You did it. You're registered, permitted, and trading legally. So why does it suddenly feel like there's a whole new set of rules?"

Getting official was step one. Staying legal while you grow, taking on staff, packaging your product, chasing bigger buyers, going online, is step two, and it catches even experienced business owners off guard. This journey walks through what changes once you start scaling, the legal groundwork most people miss, and a few creative ways to grow that don't always involve renting a second shop.



Should You Still Be a Sole Proprietor?

"You've been trading under your CIPC-registered name for a year. Is that still the right structure for what's coming next?"

Most people start as a sole proprietor or a simple private company (Pty Ltd), and that's fine for getting going. But as you grow, take on staff, sign bigger contracts, or bring in a business partner, your structure matters more. A private company (Pty Ltd) keeps your personal assets more clearly separate from business risk than a sole proprietorship does, and it's usually what bigger clients, banks, and investors expect to see before they'll sign a serious deal (Companies Act 71 of 2008).

 **QUICK TIP** You don't have to deregister and start over. You can convert or restructure through CIPC as you grow, ask them directly what changing your structure involves.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Look up whether your current structure is a sole proprietorship, a Pty Ltd, or something else, and write down one reason it might need to change in the next year.

Complete this and earn:  **"Structure Check" badge**



Hiring Your First Team Member, Legally

"You just hired your first helper. Besides paying them, what does the law actually require of you now?"

The moment you pay someone to work for you, even part-time or family, you become an employer in the eyes of the law. You must register for UIF (Unemployment Insurance Fund) with the Department of Employment and Labour within a few days of hiring (Unemployment Insurance Act 63 of 2001; Unemployment Insurance Contributions Act 4 of 2002), and register for COIDA (Compensation for Occupational Injuries and Diseases) too, which covers your employee if they're hurt on the job (COIDA, Act 130 of 1993). Both apply even if you only have one employee. The Basic Conditions of Employment Act (Act 75 of 1997) also sets minimum rules on things like working hours, leave, and pay slips.

 **QUICK TIP** Register for UIF and COIDA together when you hire your first person, most employers only think of one and get caught out by the other.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** If you already have staff, check whether you're registered for both UIF and COIDA. If you don't yet, write down the date you plan to hire and register by.

Complete this and earn:  **"Fair Employer" badge**



Getting Retail-Ready: What Big Buyers Actually Check

"A retail buyer says they're interested, then asks for your food safety certification. Do you have anything beyond your CoA?"

Your municipal Certificate of Acceptability gets you trading legally, but big retailers and formal distributors often want more before they'll list you: proof of consistent food safety practice, sometimes a recognised system like HACCP, and NRCS approval if your product is canned, smoked, or vacuum-packed. Many also run their own supplier audits. None of this happens overnight, so it's worth finding out what a specific buyer needs before you approach them, rather than after.



 **QUICK TIP** Ask a potential buyer for their supplier checklist before your first meeting. It tells you exactly what to fix first, instead of guessing.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Pick one retailer or distributor you'd like to supply, and find out what their supplier requirements are.

Complete this and earn:  "Retail Ready" badge

The Packaging Rule Growing Businesses Miss

"You've started packaging your sauce in your own branded bottles. Did you know that makes you legally responsible for what happens to that bottle after it's thrown away?"

Once you're a producer or brand owner putting packaging onto the market in any real volume, South Africa's Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) regulations under the National Environmental Management: Waste Act may apply to you (Waste Act 59 of 2008; EPR Regulations, GN R.1184 of 2020). In practice, this means registering with an approved Producer Responsibility Organisation (PRO) and contributing toward the collection and recycling of your packaging. Very small operations are often exempt, but the thresholds are lower than most people expect, so it's worth checking rather than assuming you're too small.

 **QUICK TIP** Search for a Producer Responsibility Organisation in your packaging category (plastics, paper, glass, metal) and ask them directly whether your volumes require you to register.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Look at your current packaging and note what material it's made from, then check whether an EPR scheme applies to that material.

Complete this and earn:  "Packaging Aware" badge

TM Protecting the Name You Built

"Someone in another town starts using a name almost identical to yours. Can you actually stop them?"

Registering your business with CIPC protects your company's legal identity (Companies Act 71 of 2008), but it doesn't automatically protect your brand name, logo, or recipe name from being copied by someone else. For that, you need a trademark, registered separately through CIPC's Trade Marks division (Companies Act 71 of 2008). If your business has a name, look, or product people already recognise, a trademark is what stops a competitor from trading on your reputation.

 **QUICK TIP** You can search the CIPC trade marks register yourself before you apply, to check your name isn't already taken.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Search cipc.co.za to see whether your business name or logo is already trademarked by someone else, or by you.

Complete this and earn: TM "Brand Protector" badge

Doors That Open With B-BBEE and a Tax Clearance

"A corporate client wants to place a big order, but first they ask for your B-BBEE certificate and a tax clearance. Do you have either?"

Many corporates and all government departments are required to buy from businesses with good Broad-Based Black Economic Empowerment (B-BBEE) standing (B-BBEE Act 53 of 2003), and from suppliers who are tax compliant. If your annual turnover is below the exempted micro-enterprise (EME) threshold, you likely qualify for an automatic B-BBEE certificate, sometimes just a sworn affidavit, at no cost. A SARS Tax Compliance Status (what used to be called a tax clearance certificate) is free to obtain online once your tax affairs are in order (SARS), and both documents are often the first thing a bigger buyer or a government tender asks for.

 **QUICK TIP** Get your SARS Tax Compliance Status and B-BBEE affidavit sorted before you need them, not after a big opportunity is already on the table.



 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Check your SARS eFiling profile for your current Tax Compliance Status, and look up whether your turnover qualifies you for an EME B-BBEE affidavit.
Complete this and earn:  **"Deal Ready" badge**

Selling Online? Know Your Customer Data Duties

"You start taking orders and payments through WhatsApp and a simple website. Did you know you now have legal duties around your customers' personal information?"

The moment you collect customer details like names, phone numbers, addresses, or payment information, even informally, the Protection of Personal Information Act (POPIA, Act 4 of 2013) applies to you. You don't need complicated systems, but you do need to keep that information secure, only use it for what you told the customer you'd use it for, and be able to delete it if they ask. The Consumer Protection Act (Act 68 of 2008) also gives online customers rights around refunds, delivery, and clear pricing that a cash-only stall doesn't usually have to think about.

 **QUICK TIP** Write one short line customers see when they order, saying what you'll use their details for. That alone puts you well ahead of most small businesses.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** List every piece of customer information your business currently collects, and check where and how securely you're storing it.

Complete this and earn:  **"Data Responsible" badge**

Growth Moves Most Food Businesses Overlook

"Everyone scales by opening a second stall. What if that's not actually your best option?"

Renting a second location isn't the only way to grow, and it's often the most expensive. Co-packing lets another registered, NRCS-approved facility manufacture your product at scale under your brand, so you can supply retailers without building your own factory. A cloud kitchen, cooking only for delivery from a shared commercial kitchen, cuts your rent and staffing risk compared to a second storefront. Subscription boxes and pre-order models let you produce against confirmed demand instead of guessing. And since the launch of the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA), some South African food producers are exploring exporting into other African markets, though this brings its own permit and standards requirements worth researching properly before you commit.

 **QUICK TIP** Before spending on a second physical location, cost out co-packing or a shared cloud kitchen instead. The legal and financial commitment is usually much smaller.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Pick one growth option from this lesson you hadn't seriously considered, and write down what you'd need to find out to explore it.

Complete this and earn:  **"Growth Thinker" badge**

Sources for Fact-Checking: Legislation & Regulation

Every legal fact in Journeys 3, 4, and 10 is drawn from current South African legislation and regulator guidance:

- Regulations Governing General Hygiene Requirements for Food Premises (R638 of 2018), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — enforced by municipal Environmental Health Departments.
- Regulations Relating to the Labelling and Advertising of Foodstuffs (R146), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — Department of Health.
- Businesses Act 71 of 1991 — gov.za.
- Companies Act 71 of 2008 and Companies and Intellectual Property Commission (CIPC) — company registration, business structure conversion, and trade mark registration — cipc.co.za.
- National Regulator for Compulsory Specifications (NRCS), Food and Associated Industries division — canned, smoked, and vacuum-packed products — nrcs.org.za.



- South African Revenue Service (SARS), Small Businesses – Taxpayers, Tax Compliance Status system, and Budget 2026 Frequently Asked Questions (VAT and Turnover Tax threshold changes effective 1 April 2026) — sars.gov.za.
- Unemployment Insurance Act 63 of 2001 and Unemployment Insurance Contributions Act 4 of 2002 — Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- Compensation for Occupational Injuries and Diseases Act 130 of 1993 (COIDA) — Compensation Fund, Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- Basic Conditions of Employment Act 75 of 1997 — Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- National Environmental Management: Waste Act 59 of 2008 and Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) Regulations (Government Notice R.1184, 2020) — Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment — dffe.gov.za.
- Broad-Based Black Economic Empowerment Act 53 of 2003, and the Codes of Good Practice on B-BBEE (Exempted Micro-Enterprise thresholds) — dtic.gov.za.
- Protection of Personal Information Act 4 of 2013 (POPIA) — Information Regulator South Africa — info regulator.org.za.
- Consumer Protection Act 68 of 2008 — online and distance sales provisions — gov.za.
- African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) — South African implementation guidance — dtic.gov.za.

Note: municipal fees, thresholds, and application processes vary by area and are periodically revised by government and regulators. Verify current requirements directly with the relevant municipality or regulator before publishing final figures in the app.

Sources & Further Reading: Business Practice, Marketing & Financial Literacy

Branding and digital marketing facts in Journeys 6 and 7 draw on the following:

- Cloudfusion (2025). 7 Essential Reasons Why Branding Is Important for Business. [Cloudfusion.co.za](https://cloudfusion.co.za).
- Dandu, R. (2015). What Is Branding and Why Is It Important for Your Business? [Brandingmag](https://brandingmag.com).
- Mercer, S. (2026). What to Post When You Have Nothing to Post: 10 Content Ideas for Summerville Businesses. What's Up Summerville.
- Why food photography is important for your food business. candyfoxstudio.com.
- Yolisa Motha (2021). A Guide to Branding a Small Business. [ikhokha](https://ikhokha.com).

Statistics on South African small business communication, time management, professionalism, networking, record-keeping, and banking (Journeys 1, 2, 8, and 9) are drawn from national small business research. Verify current figures against original sources before publishing final numbers in the app.

Growth-readiness, lending-risk, funding, and stock-management facts in Journeys 1, 2, 5, and 9 draw on the following:

- National Debt Advisors (2021). Stay away from unregistered money-lenders. nationaldebtadvisors.co.za.
- Startup Mag (2025). Scaling Signals: Ten Signs Your Small Business Is Ready to Grow. startupmag.co.za; Lula (2025). 5 Signs Your Business is Ready for Growth Capital. lula.co.za.
- RegInsights (2024). Small Business Funding. regenesys.net/reginsights.
- Graduates24 (n.d.). NYDA Grant Programme Small Business Funding in South Africa. graduates24.com.
- Okhantu (2025). SEDFA Funding 2026: Requirements, Amounts & How to Apply. okhantu.co.za.
- Ready Accounting (2026). Inventory management tips for cost savings and efficiency. readyaccounting.co.za.
- Xtraspace (2024). Small Business Inventory Management in SA: 10 Top Tips. xtraspace.co.za.

Sources & Further Reading: The VUCA Concept

The mission statement on the cover page draws on the following:

- Bennett, N., & Lemoine, G. J. (2014). What VUCA Really Means for You. *Harvard Business Review*, 92(1/2), 27.

